The 199th Test

On 6 November 2013, the West Indies won the toss and decided to bat first. There was a sizeable crowd at Eden Gardens on the first morning. Making a rare exception to her routine of praying at home, Anjali had come to see the match and it was a real surprise for me to see her and Arjun in the stands. When I had spoken to her the night before, I had sensed that something was cooking but didn't know exactly what. It turned out she had spoken with my friend and co-writer Boria Majumdar and planned the visit as a surprise. I became aware of her presence only when an announcement was made that she was in the stands. I must say it was a delight to see them both when we met up at the end of the day's play.

This is what Anjali told me about making that special trip to Kolkata. It was a ritual with us that she would wish me well on the eve of a Test series. Before leaving for Kolkata, I had said to Anjali that it would be the last time she would have to do so. Anjali told me later that as I left for the airport with Ajit, who always dropped me off whenever I travelled, she could not control her tears. She had to go to meet Arjun's cricket coaches, who had come from England, at the Waterstones Club, which was close to the airport, and so she was in a car behind me for most of the way, with tears rolling down her cheeks. Even when she reached the club, she just could not control her emotions and burst into tears when she met up with Arjun's coaches. The poor chaps did not understand why coming to see them had made her cry! That's when she told them the real reason and then they insisted on accompanying her to Kolkata to watch me play.

We had bowled the West Indies out for 234 on the first day and I was keen to do well when I went out to bat on the morning of day two. I had played a couple of good shots when I fell to an lbw decision I wasn't very happy with. These things are part of the game, of course, but it seemed to me that the ball from the off-spinner Shane Shillingford was going over the stumps. It was frustrating, but there was nothing I could do about it. Replays showed the ball was going at least six inches over the stumps.

Having lost a few quick wickets, we were under pressure when Rohit Sharma and Ashwin started a rebuilding act. Rohit played spectacularly on debut and Ashwin was the perfect foil. Both got hundreds and their